THE WHOLE STORY · SMALL GROUP GUIDE · LESSON 23 OF 26

Acts: The Spirit and the Church

Acts 1–12

> **The big idea:** Fifty days after the resurrection, the risen Jesus poured out the Holy Spirit at Pentecost. Peter preached, three thousand were baptized, and the church was born. The first believers devoted themselves to God's word, fellowship, the breaking of bread, and prayer. Persecution only spread the word, and the gospel moved from Jerusalem to Samaria to the Gentiles, just as Jesus said it would.

Before you meet: Read

Acts 1:1–11 | Acts 2:1–47 | Acts 4:1–31 | Acts 8:26–40 | Acts 10:1–48

Open (5 minutes)

Think of a group you belonged to that felt like family. What made it feel that way?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"But you will receive _____ when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses." *(Acts 1:8)*

"Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the _____ of your sins." *(Acts 2:38)*

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the _____, to the breaking of bread and the prayers." *(Acts 2:42)*

"And there is _____ in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved." *(Acts 4:12)*

"We must obey _____ rather than men." *(Acts 5:29)*

"Truly I understand that God shows no _____." *(Acts 10:34)*

Discuss

1. Jesus said it was to their advantage that he go away. Why would having the Spirit be better than having Jesus physically present? *John 16:7; John 14:16–17*

2. At Pentecost each person heard the gospel in his own language. How does that reverse what happened at Babel? *Acts 2:5–11; Genesis 11:7–9*

3. The crowd asked, What shall we do? What did Peter tell them, and what does that mean for you? *Acts 2:37–39*

4. Which of the four marks in Acts 2:42 is strongest in your life? Which is weakest? *Acts 2:42–47*

5. Persecution scattered the believers, and they preached wherever they went. Have you seen hardship spread the gospel? *Acts 8:1–4*

6. Peter had to learn that God shows no partiality. What barriers between people does the gospel break down today? *Acts 10:28, 34–35; Ephesians 2:19–22*

Apply this week

Read Acts 1–4 and 9–10 this week and note every time the Holy Spirit is mentioned. Pick the weakest of the four marks in Acts 2:42 and take one step to strengthen it. If you are not part of a local church, visit one that preaches the Bible this Sunday.

Memory verse

"But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

Acts 1:8

Pray

Thank God for pouring out his Spirit on his people. Ask him to make you devoted to his word, to his people, to the Lord's Supper, and to prayer. Pray by name for one person you want to hear the gospel, and ask for boldness to speak.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 23

Acts: The Spirit and the Church

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Acts 2:1–4 and 2:36–47 aloud together.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 1, 3, and 4 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Witnesses circles and the What the Holy Spirit Does chart in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 24 (Acts 9:1–31, 13–14, 16; Romans 1:16–17; 5:1–11).

Main points to land

1. The Holy Spirit is a Person, fully God with the Father and the Son, sent by the risen Christ to dwell in his people (John 14:16–17; Acts 2:33; WSC 6).
2. At Pentecost the Spirit came, the gospel was preached in many languages, and three thousand repented and were baptized. The promise is for you and for your children (Acts 2:1–41).
3. The church grows by ordinary means: God's word, the sacraments, and prayer, lived out in fellowship (Acts 2:42; WSC 88).
4. Salvation is in Christ alone, and persecution cannot stop his word; it spreads it (Acts 4:12; 8:4; 12:24).
5. The gospel crosses every barrier, from Jerusalem to Samaria to the Gentiles, fulfilling the promise to Abraham (Acts 1:8; 10:34; 11:18; Genesis 12:3).

Core doctrine to teach

Baptism CORE DOCTRINE 23 OF 26

Baptism is the sign Jesus commanded for his people: washing with water in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. It marks a person as belonging to Christ and joins them to his church. The water itself does not save. Christ saves, and baptism is his visible sign and promise of cleansing and new life in him. *Matthew 28:19; Acts 2:38–41; Romans 6:3–4*

Answer key (Observe)

1. power
2. forgiveness
3. fellowship
4. salvation
5. God

6. partiality

Questions people will ask

Do Christians today still speak in tongues like at Pentecost?
At Pentecost the tongues were real languages the crowd understood (Acts 2:6–8), a sign that the gospel was going to every nation. Christians differ on whether such gifts continue. What every Christian agrees on is the main point: the same Spirit now lives in every believer and makes us witnesses (Romans 8:9; Acts 1:8).

Does Acts 2:38 mean baptism saves you?
No. Forgiveness comes through faith in Christ alone (Acts 10:43; 16:31). Baptism is the sign and seal God gives to his people, and Peter calls them to receive it together with repentance, because it pictures the forgiveness Christ gives. The water does not save, but Christ, whom it signifies, does (WSC 94).

Did the first Christians share everything because they were forced to?
No. Peter told Ananias the property was his to keep and the money was at his disposal (Acts 5:4). Their giving was voluntary, the overflow of grace. The point is love that meets real needs, not a law requiring everyone to sell everything.

Why did Saul persecute the church, and how could God use him?
Saul believed Jesus was a false Messiah and that the church was a threat to God's law (Philippians 3:6). The risen Jesus met him on the road and changed him (Acts 9:1–6). Paul later called himself the foremost of sinners, saved as an example of Christ's patience (1 Timothy 1:15–16).

Closing prayer

Lord Jesus, you poured out your Spirit on your people and built your church. Fill us with your Spirit. Make us devoted to your word, to one another, to your table, and to prayer. Give us boldness to speak of what we have seen and heard, and send your word to the people we love. Amen.